

Youth Church Orchestra Aims to Help Musicians of Color

For more than two years, Ebonie Vazquez searched to find a music teacher of color for her son, Giovanni. He is 11 years old and loves to play the violin. Now, she has found that teacher at New Hope Presbyterian Church, a Christian religious center, near Los Angeles, California.

Chineta Goodjoin, a Black pastor, leads New Hope. She started a string orchestra at the church in April to help children of color have a better chance to learn classical music.

Goodjoin and the orchestra's leaders think it is important for the music teachers to look like their students and share similar life experiences. That is why the orchestra's director, Charles Dickerson and all its music teachers are people of color.

Dickerson is also the director of the Inner City Youth Orchestra of Los Angeles, which he founded in 2009. After Goodjoin's daughter Nyla began playing in that orchestra, Goodjoin decided to build a similar group at her church.

The church's orchestra now has about 18 members, aged nine to 20. They play the violin, viola, bass and cello. The orchestra accepts all students who want to join.

Johnathan Nealy, left, learns how to play the violin as part of an initiative that aims to promote equity in classical music at New Hope Presbyterian Church on Wednesday, Oct. 16, 2024, in Anaheim, California. (AP Photo/William Liang)

Ebonie Vazquez says having teachers of color has helped the orchestra members feel like they fit in well.

"It's important they don't feel like outsiders, but are supported and feel like they belong," she said. "It has definitely helped my son connect more to the music and the craft."

Her son Giovanni said that in the church orchestra, he could play classical music or popular modern music. He values being part of the church orchestra because "it's a piece of our community."

"They encourage young musicians of color and everyone gets a chance to play and maybe use it as a stepping stone to get better or even turn this into a career," he said.

Elizabeth Moulthrop is executive director of El Sistema, an international network of music education programs that was founded in Venezuela.

She said programs like the church orchestra can help students go to life-changing summer music camps, receive college scholarships, and find connections to jobs.

Johnathan Nealy plays the violin as part of a string music program at New Hope Presbyterian Church on Wednesday, Oct. 16, 2024, in Anaheim, California. (AP Photo/William Liang)

Goodjoin said she and her husband, Reggie Goodjoin, see a future for the orchestra where “African American kids play classical music and play it well.” Reggie Goodjoin is a jazz musician and the church’s music director.

The group plays a mix of both classical and popular music. “I like to say they play everything from Bach to Beyonce,” added Goodjoin. They also learn music by famous African American jazz composers such as Count Basie and Duke Ellington.

Rev. Chineta Goodjoin, who has started a string orchestra to promote young musicians of color, poses for a portrait in the sanctuary of New Hope Presbyterian Church on Wednesday, Oct. 16, 2024, in Anaheim, Calif. (AP Photo/William Liang)

Goodjoin said she believes the church is a great place to start talking about fairness in music. “Music is freedom,” Goodjoin added.

The pastor is already getting praise from parents. One boy who plays the upright bass was about to quit playing because no one in his school orchestra looked like him.

“His mom said that when he came here, the pressure to play and compete was taken off and that it’s a delight to now watch her son light up feeling a sense of worthiness,” she said.

A string orchestra, part of an initiative to promote equity in classical music, rehearses at New Hope Presbyterian Church on Wednesday, Oct. 16, 2024, in Anaheim, California. (AP Photo/William Liang)

Dickerson said he started the Los Angeles orchestra when a group of students told him they wanted to play closer to where they live.

“They would have to drive long distances to be in these orchestras where they didn’t know the other kids,” he said. “The young kids from our communities were always put in the back row and the back row was right next to the door.”

“It’s easy to walk out that door,” he added, “when you don’t really feel accepted and when you know you’re probably not as skilled as the others.” He added that those other students usually had more music lessons and started playing at a younger age.

Dickerson said the Black Church has at times been the only place the African American community could organize services they needed, such as banks and newspapers.

“If we can come together in the church and create a symphonic orchestra, all I can say is all praise to God,” he added.

I'm Andrew Smith. And I'm Anna Matteo.

Deepa Bharath wrote this story for The Associated Press. Andrew Smith adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

pastor -n. ศิษยาภิบาล - ผู้นำของคริสตจักร

outsider -n. คนนอก - บุคคลที่ไม่ใช่ส่วนหนึ่งของกลุ่มใดกลุ่มหนึ่ง

craft -n. งานฝีมือ - กิจกรรมที่เกี่ยวข้องกับการทำบางสิ่งบางอย่างอย่างมีทักษะ

encourage -v. สนับสนุน - ช่วยให้ผู้คนต้องการทำสิ่งต่างๆ

a stepping stone -noun phrase. บันไดสู่ความสำเร็จ - ประสบการณ์ที่สามารถช่วยให้คุณก้าวหน้า โดยเฉพาะในอาชีพของคุณ

delight -n. ความสุข - สิ่งที่น่ามาซึ่งความสุข

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What was Ebonie Vazquez's primary goal regarding her son Giovanni's music education?

- A) To find a school that specialized in violin.
- B) To ensure he played classical music.
- C) To find a music teacher who was a person of color.
- D) To enroll him in a church-based music program.

2. Who initiated the string orchestra at New Hope Presbyterian Church and why?

- A) Ebonie Vazquez, to find a teacher for her son.
- B) Giovanni, due to his love for classical music.
- C) Chineta Goodjoin, to promote classical music education for children of color.
- D) Charles Dickerson, to expand his existing orchestra.

3. According to Goodjoin and the orchestra's leaders, what is a crucial characteristic for the music teachers in the program?

- A) They must be highly experienced classical musicians.
- B) They should have a background in teaching popular music.
- C) They need to be people of color who share similar life experiences with the students.
- D) They must be members of the New Hope Presbyterian Church.

4. What inspired Chineta Goodjoin to establish a similar music group at her church?

- A) Her desire to collaborate with Charles Dickerson.
- B) The success of her daughter Nyla playing in Dickerson's Inner City Youth Orchestra.

- C) A request from Ebonie Vazquez.
- D) The lack of classical music options in Los Angeles.

5. What is the age range and approximate number of members in the church's string orchestra?

- A) Members are all under 18, numbering around 20.
- B) The orchestra has about 18 members, aged nine to 20.
- C) It includes exactly 9 to 20 members, all playing the violin.
- D) It is open to all ages, with at least 18 members.

6. How did Ebonie Vazquez observe the impact of having teachers of color on the orchestra members, including her son?

- A) It made them feel competitive with each other.
- B) It helped them connect more with the music and feel a sense of belonging.
- C) It caused some members to feel like outsiders.
- D) It primarily improved their technical skills on their instruments.

7. What does Giovanni appreciate most about being part of the church orchestra?

- A) The opportunity to only play classical music.
- B) The strict discipline required to improve.
- C) Its role as a community piece and a potential stepping stone for young musicians of color.
- D) The competitive environment that pushes him to excel.

8. According to Elizabeth Moulthrop of El Sistema, what potential benefits can programs like the church orchestra offer students?

- A) Exclusive access to advanced classical music training.
- B) Opportunities for summer music camps, scholarships, and job connections.
- C) A chance to perform only popular modern music.
- D) Direct entry into a professional music career without further education.

9. What is the vision that Chineta and Reggie Goodjoin have for the orchestra's future?

- A) To expand the program globally.
- B) To focus solely on jazz music.
- C) To see African American children excel in classical music.
- D) To merge with the Inner City Youth Orchestra of Los Angeles.

10. The orchestra's repertoire includes music from which of the following categories?

- A) Only classical pieces by European composers.

- B) Exclusively popular modern songs.
- C) A blend of classical and popular music, including works by African American jazz composers.
- D) Primarily contemporary orchestral compositions.

11. According to Goodjoin, what role does the church play in discussions about music?

- A) It serves as a neutral venue for community meetings.
- B) It is an ideal place to address issues of fairness in music.
- C) It primarily focuses on religious hymns and gospel music.
- D) It is where musicians can find freedom from traditional rules.

12. What positive outcome did a parent report after her son joined the New Hope orchestra, particularly regarding his previous experience?

- A) He immediately became a lead performer.
- B) He was able to compete at a higher level than before.
- C) The pressure to compete was removed, and he gained a sense of worthiness.
- D) He found other students who looked exactly like him.

13. According to Charles Dickerson, what challenges did students from certain communities face in traditional orchestras before his initiatives?

- A) They were often placed in prominent positions due to their talent.
- B) They found it difficult to connect with students from similar backgrounds.
- C) They had to travel long distances, were often marginalized (back row), and felt unaccepted due to perceived skill gaps.
- D) They lacked access to any music education programs.

14. Historically, what significant role has the Black Church played for the African American community, according to Dickerson?

- A) It has been primarily a place for musical performances.
- B) It served as the sole institution for organizing essential community services.
- C) It provided financial assistance for aspiring musicians.
- D) It was the main place for political activism.

15. What does Charles Dickerson imply about the achievement of creating a symphonic orchestra within the church setting?

- A) It is a testament to overcoming significant logistical challenges.
- B) It signifies a successful integration of secular and religious music.
- C) He attributes its creation to divine intervention and praise.

D) It demonstrates the church's new focus on artistic endeavors.